CampusSwap — UX Research Plan

A campus-only app for students to buy, sell and give away dorm items within their own dorm community.

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Course: UX/UI for Startups

Study length: 1 week

Methods: Interviews + Survey + Competitive analysis

1. Project background

Every semester, students move into and out of the university dorms. People leaving throw away or abandon usable items: kettles, desk lamps, hangers, textbooks, mattress toppers, sports gear. At the same time, newcomers buy the same items new, often at a higher price and with delivery delays. Today these exchanges happen in noisy Telegram flea-market chats, on general marketplaces like Avito, or by word of mouth. Those channels are hard to search, posts quickly get buried, and arranging a handover between buildings takes many messages.

CampusSwap explores whether a dedicated, campus-only marketplace can make it faster and more trustworthy for students to pass items on to each other, reducing waste and saving money. This study will help us understand students' current behavior and pain points before we design anything.

2. Research goals

1. **Understand current behavior:** how students currently get rid of and get dorm items, and which channels they use.
2. **Find pain points:** what makes buying, selling or giving away items between students slow, frustrating or risky.
3. **Understand trust and handover:** what makes students trust another student, and what makes the pickup or handover easy or hard.

Scope note: this study focuses on student-to-student exchange of physical items inside the campus. It does not cover payments infrastructure, delivery services, or selling to people outside the university.

3. Key research questions

1. What types of items do students buy, sell or give away, and at what moments (move-in, move-out, mid-semester)?
2. Which channels do students use today (Telegram chats, Avito, friends, leaving items in common areas), and why those?
3. What frustrates students most about these channels (finding items, spam, slow replies, haggling, no-shows)?
4. What information do students need before deciding to take an item (photos, condition, price, location, seller info)?
5. What makes students trust or distrust another student in an exchange?
6. How do students arrange the handover, and what goes wrong?
7. What motivates students to sell versus give items away for free?

4. Methods

A. Semi-structured interviews (primary)

- **Who:** 5–6 dorm residents matching the recruiting criteria.
- **Format:** 20–30 minutes, in person or by video/Telegram call.
- **How:** follow the interview guide (section 6) but let participants tell stories about real past exchanges. Ask "tell me about the last time…" rather than hypotheticals. Record audio with consent and take notes.
- **Why:** gives depth: motivations, emotions, and the real steps of an exchange.

B. Online survey (validation)

- **Who:** 30+ students living in the dorms.
- **Format:** Google Forms, about 5 minutes, shared in dorm and course Telegram chats.
- **How:** launch after the first 3 interviews so questions reflect real themes. Analyze answer frequencies and cross-check them with interview findings.
- **Why:** shows how common each behavior and pain point is across more students.

C. Competitive analysis (supporting)

Compare existing options students use today: **Telegram flea-market chats, Avito, Facebook Marketplace / VK groups, and campus "free shelf" corners**. Criteria: search and filters, campus-only audience, trust signals (profiles, ratings), free give-away support, handover coordination, notifications for wanted items. Output: a ✓/✗ comparison table that shows the gap CampusSwap could fill.

Timeline

Day	Activity
1	Finalize plan, post recruiting message, screen participants, competitive analysis
2–3	Interviews 1–3, then adjust and launch the survey
4–5	Interviews 4–6, survey stays open
6	Close survey, put interview notes on sticky notes in FigJam (one color per participant)
7	Affinity mapping, key findings, research report

5. Recruiting criteria

Must have

- Currently a student at the university and living in the campus dorms.
- Has lived in the dorms for at least one semester (or has just moved in, if fewer than 2 such people are found).
- Has bought, sold, given away or received at least one used item from another student in the last 12 months, *or* has thrown away or bought new an item they could have exchanged.

Mix we aim for (across 5–6 participants)

- At least 2 who mostly **give or sell** items and at least 2 who mostly **get or buy** items.
- Different study years (first-year to master's), including at least 1 who is moving out soon.
- At least 1 international student and at least 1 local student.
- Mixed genders.

Exclude

- Close friends and teammates (to reduce bias).
- Students who have already seen the CampusSwap concept.

Screener questions

1. Do you currently live in the campus dorms? (Yes / No) — *must be Yes*
2. How long have you lived there? (<1 semester / 1–2 semesters / 3+ semesters)
3. In the last 12 months, have you bought, sold, given away or received a used item from another student? (Bought / Sold / Gave away / Received / None)
4. What year are you in, and are you a local or international student?
5. Are you available for a 25-minute chat this week? (Yes / No)

Recruiting message (Telegram)

> *Hi everyone! I'm Ahmed, working on a UX course project about how students in the dorms buy, sell and give away stuff to each other (kettles, lamps, books, etc.). I'm looking for 5–6 dorm residents for a 25-minute chat this week. No preparation needed, just your experience. If you're up for it, fill in this 1-minute form: [screener link]. Thank you!* 🙏

6. Interview guide

Introduction (≈3 min)

> *Hi [name], thank you for joining! I'm Ahmed, and I'm working on a UX design course project. I want to learn how students in the dorms get and pass on everyday items, like furniture, kitchen stuff or books. There are no right or wrong answers. I'm interested in your real experience, and I'm not testing you. The session takes about 25 minutes. Is it OK if I record the audio? It's only for my notes and won't be shared. You can skip any question or stop at any time. Do you have any questions before we start?*

Questions guide (≈20 min)

	Question	Rationale
Warm-up		
1	Tell me a bit about yourself: what do you study, and how long have you lived in the dorms?	Builds rapport and gives context (study year, how long in dorms) to segment findings.
2	When you first moved into the dorm, what did you need to get for your room, and how did you get it?	Reveals move-in needs and which channels newcomers rely on (Goal 1, RQ 1–2).
Getting items		
3	Tell me about the last time you got a used item from another student. What was it, and how did it happen from start to finish?	A concrete story shows the real steps and channels, not opinions (Goal 1, RQ 2).
4	How did you find that item? What did you look at before deciding to take it?	Shows search behavior and the information needed to decide (RQ 4).
5	Have you ever bought something new that you later found out someone on campus was giving away or selling? What happened?	Tests the core problem: missed exchanges and wasted money (Goal 2).
Passing items on		
6	Tell me about the last time you wanted to get rid of something. What did you do with it?	Covers the seller/giver side and current channels (Goal 1, RQ 2).
7	How did you decide whether to sell it, give it away, or throw it out?	Uncovers motivations for selling vs giving free (RQ 7).
8	If you posted it somewhere, how did that go? How many people replied, and how long did it take?	Measures posting effort, reach and response time (Goal 2, RQ 3).
Channels and pain points		
9	Which chats, apps or places do you use for this? What do you like and dislike about each?	Feeds the competitive analysis with real user opinions (RQ 2–3).

10	What is the most annoying part of buying, selling or giving away things on campus?	Directly surfaces the biggest pain point to design for (Goal 2, RQ 3).
Trust and handover		
11	Before meeting someone you don't know for an exchange, what makes you feel OK or not OK about it?	Identifies trust signals the product must show (Goal 3, RQ 5).
12	Has an exchange ever gone wrong, like a no-show, an item in worse condition, or a price argument? Tell me what happened.	Critical incidents reveal risks and needed safeguards (Goal 3, RQ 5–6).
13	How do you usually agree on where and when to hand an item over? What makes that easy or hard?	Explores handover coordination, a likely key app flow (Goal 3, RQ 6).
Looking ahead		
14	If you had a magic wand to make swapping things on campus easier, what would it do?	Opens space for unmet needs and feature ideas without suggesting a solution (all goals).

Probes to use throughout: "Why was that?", "Can you show me?" (e.g., the Telegram chat), "How did you feel about that?", "What did you do next?"

Wrap-up (≈2 min)

> *That's all my questions, thank you so much! Is there anything about buying, selling or giving away things on campus that we didn't talk about but you think is important? … Later I'll be testing early designs. Would you be OK if I reached out to you again? Thanks again, this really helps.*

7. Survey

Google Forms, about 5 minutes, anonymous. Shared in dorm and course Telegram chats. Target: 30+ responses.

	Question	Format	Rationale
1	Do you currently live in the campus dorms?	Yes / No (No → end)	Screens out non-target respondents.
2	What is your year of study?	Single choice: Bachelor 1–4, Master 1–2, Other	Lets us compare newcomers with experienced residents.
3	In the last 12 months, which of these have you done with another student?	Multiple choice: Bought / Sold / Gave away for free / Received for free / None	Measures how common each type of exchange is (RQ 1).
4	Which types of items have you exchanged or wanted to exchange?	Multiple choice: Kitchen items, Lamps/electronics, Furniture/storage, Bedding, Textbooks, Sports gear, Clothes, Other	Identifies the most important item categories (RQ 1).
5	When do you most often need to get or get rid of items?	Multiple choice: Moving in, Moving out, Start of semester, Mid-semester, Anytime	Reveals timing peaks for notifications and campaigns (RQ 1).
6	Which channels do you use to find or offer items?	Multiple choice: Telegram chats, Avito, VK/other social groups, Friends, Leaving items in common areas, None	Validates current channels from interviews (RQ 2).
7	How satisfied are you with these channels?	Likert 1–5 (Very dissatisfied → Very satisfied)	Quantifies how big the problem is (Goal 2).

8	What are the biggest problems you face? (pick up to 3)	Multiple choice (max 3): Hard to find items, Posts get lost, Slow or no replies, Unclear condition, Price haggling, No-shows, Arranging pickup, Don't trust strangers, Other	Ranks pain points to prioritize features (RQ 3).
9	Rank what matters most when deciding to take an item.	Ranking: Price, Photos, Condition description, Distance/building, Seller rating/profile, Quick reply	Shows which information belongs in a listing (RQ 4).
10	What would make you trust another student for an exchange? (pick up to 2)	Multiple choice (max 2): Verified university account, Ratings/reviews, Mutual contacts, Meeting in a public spot, Profile photo, Other	Identifies the most valued trust signals (Goal 3, RQ 5).
11	In the last year, have you thrown away an item that someone else could have used?	Yes / No / Not sure	Measures waste: an argument for the product's value (Goal 2).
12	How likely would you be to use a campus-only app for buying, selling and giving away items?	Likert 1–5 (Very unlikely → Very likely)	Early demand signal (all goals).
13	Anything else you'd like to share about exchanging items on campus?	Open text (optional)	Catches insights the closed questions missed.

8. Expected outputs

- Interview notes as sticky notes in FigJam, one color per participant
- Affinity map with themes and "How might we…?" questions
- Survey results charts
- Competitive analysis table
- Research report: executive summary, key findings with quotes, recommendations